

« Dreams of winning Olympic gold at LA 2028 keep me up at night »

SAURAV GHOSAL

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Picture this. You've dedicated over 30 years of your life to a sport, 21 of those competing at the highest level, and it is now time to take a few steps back. How must that feel? Ask veteran Indian squash player Saurav Ghosal, who recently announced his retirement from the PSA tour, the professional circuit of the sport, at the age of 37.

In the five weeks between mentally making peace with his decision and the actual announcement, Ghosal has been reliving the best and worst of his storied career in conversations with peers, tributes in the media, and messages from his opponents and fans alike.

It has been some time since he last picked up a squash racquet, and he is now embracing a slower pace of life, indulging in activities he couldn't enjoy while fully immersed in the demands of competitive squash. However, Ghosal is not finished with his passion for squash and has his eyes set on the Los Angeles Summer Olympics in 2028.

Between an impressive Asian Games campaign last year and

now, what changed? When did you feel like you're done with the PSA circuit, and when did discussions about retirement begin?

On the last night of the Asian Games, which was the individual final, it just felt in some ways that it was an endpoint, but I didn't want to read into it a lot because I lost that day, got slightly injured, and felt like it was just too raw a time to be able to take any sort of decision.

So, I put it in the back of my mind. I thought I'd just get away. I was injured anyway and knew that I had to take some time off to recover and then come back and see how I felt, and that's what I did. But for some reason, there was this nagging feeling in my head through the months that I was still playing. I was going into tournaments thinking about that at different points in time, which has never happened to me in my career before.

Sometimes, when you're going to the airport, you're like, "Ah, I wish I didn't have to go." Once I'm at the tournament, I've

always been very excited to play and compete, and playing on some very nice stages around the world has been brilliant. But these last few months, starting in November when I played my first tournament after the Asian Games and leading up to the Windy City Open in Chicago in February, there were different points in time where I felt like mentally I wasn't fully there. Physically, too, certain small things were going on with my body that weren't letting me play at my very best. Nothing major, but things that were just holding me back. That made me sit up and take notice a little bit more.